

Re-articulating North-South Collaborations in HCI

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ABSTRACT

Research connecting the ‘Global South’ and ‘Global North’ is not new to HCI. However, over the last few years we have seen a prominent shift in the ways we understand, represent and engage in North-South collaborations. Central to these discussions is the need to re-frame the nature of collaboration between and across geographies in which power dynamics, coloniality and the handling of differences are at the fore. In this panel, we will discuss experiences of HCI collaboration across the ‘Global South’ and ‘Global North’. The panel will unpack the joys, fluidity and tensions within such collaborations from various geographical perspectives, in an effort to de-homogenize the Global South, and provide ways forward for an HCI flavored re-articulation of collaboration across geo-politically established and epistemic borders.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-Centered Computing; • Human Computer Interaction (HCI);

KEYWORDS

Research collaboration, International collaboration, Global Justice

ACM Reference Format:

Reem Talhouk, Ebtissam Alabdulqader, Cat Kutay, Kagonya Awori, Marisol Wong-Villacrés, Neha Kumar, Tariq Zaman, Volker Wulf, Zainab Almeraj, and Shaimaa Lazem. 2023. Re-articulating North-South Collaborations in HCI. In *Extended Abstracts of the 2023 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '23)*, April 23–28, 2023, Hamburg, Germany. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 4 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3544549.3583752>

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CHI EA '23, April 23–28, 2023, Hamburg, Germany

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ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-9422-2/23/04.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3544549.3583752>

1 INTRODUCTION

This panel aims to initiate and extend discussions regarding configurations of North-South collaborations within our HCI community and research. Panel members from diverse geographical locations, career stages and industries will respond to questions posed by panel organizers and audience members to unpack the histories and futures that shape the epistemologies and ontologies of North-South collaborations and narratives. Through this process we hope to initiate a wider dialogue within the CHI community that celebrates North-South collaborations while also working with and against the tensions that arise surrounding power relations, epistemological plurality and diverse ways of being.

For the purposes of this panel, we will refer to collaborations between Western and non-Western researchers and institutions as North-South collaborations due to the familiarity of the term within the academic language dominant within HCI. However, we acknowledge that the language of North-South is a blunt one that is a manifestation of orientalist epistemological constructions of colonized lands and peoples [19]. We therefore propose to our audience to pause when we use the term ‘North-South collaborations’ and consider that in our use of the term we are also referring to South-North collaborations and collaborative research conducted in previously and currently colonized lands including research conducted by scholars of the Global Majority that are based in Western academia. Here, by Global Majority we are referring to peoples of color and peoples that have been racialized as ethnic minorities. Furthermore, when referring to North-South collaborations, we are also referring to collaborations between indigenous and non-indigenous communities and researchers within geographic locations occupied by both communities i.e. places in which the colonial, cultural and socio-political constructs of North and South occupy the same lands. Lastly, our conceptualization of North-South collaboration also includes the collaborative efforts of researchers from the Global North and South in building our wider HCI community.

2 BACKGROUND

We are currently writing this proposal in December 2022, as Interactions' November-December 2022 issue is arriving on our desks and screens marking the 40 year anniversary of SIGCHI [24]. The issue not only provides a view of the past, present and future of SIGCHI [14] but also highlights the ways in which SIGCHI has become a global organization [22]. The internationalization of SIGCHI membership and in turn our CHI community, can be attributed to: (1) the active efforts of researchers to establish local chapters that are building and supporting HCI research communities around the world collaborating with (2) SIGCHI Initiatives to build these chapters and facilitate further collaborations across geographical divides. The long-running workshop, now symposium, HCI Across Borders [2] has provided a space for researchers working in the 'Global South' and 'Global North' to come together and build collaborations. In 2018, the SIGCHI Across Borders Initiative [23] was launched as a series of regional meetings to discuss the future of HCI in Latin America, Africa and Asia. Building on Special Interest Groups, workshops and panels held at CHI and other ACM affiliated conferences, researchers have collaborated across borders to initiate events, conferences, summer schools and other activities with the intention of building HCI communities within varying regions and to give visibility to their diverse research. Researchers from South America first came together in 2001 and established the biannual Latin American Conference on Human-Computer Interaction [1]. Similarly, in 2016, the first AfriCHI conference was held with the intention of developing a sustainable forum for local expertise in HCI in Africa [10]. As such AfriCHI joined India HCI [26] and the Asian CHI symposium [12] as regional conferences/events supported by SIGCHI as spaces for the development and visibilizing the rich research narratives that are of and from the regions. 2017 also marked the year in which the ArabHCI initiative embarked on its journey to promote Human-Computer Interaction research and education in Arab countries [5].

The above-mentioned initiatives are just a few examples of the materialization of North-South collaborations, facilitated and supported by SIGCHI, as they came about through researchers in the North and South placing an impetus on creating space for researchers and epistemologies in the Global South to come in to conversation with research narratives shaped in the Global North. As narratives of and from the Global South strengthen, we now find ourselves holding the past and looking towards the future of North-South collaborations as dialogical epistemological and ontological spaces. In workshops, panels and publications [6–9, 11, 15, 17, 20, 25] HCI researchers of and from the Global South are raising questions on epistemological and ontological discourses that have shaped HCI research and are also attempting to disrupt the colonial legacies and debris that have played structural roles in shaping North-South collaborations [13, 21]. Their work builds on research and critical reflections that celebrate the multiple ways through which we collaborate across geographic borders as well as unpack power dynamics [21], issues of race and racism [3, 18] and epistemic violence [4, 18] that have shaped the histories of North-South collaborations.

Narratives of North-South collaborations are deeply intertwined with the ways in which research from the Global South is situated in

relation to that of the Global North. Attempts to dismantle colonial legacies embedded in the situation of research from different geographies has come under scrutiny within our community, especially in spaces in which researchers have come together to collaboratively construct infrastructures that maintain the HCI community— such as the programming of the CHI conference in itself. In CHI2013, research from the Global South was grouped and presented in a session titled “Developing the World” [16], thus highlighting the hold that colonial narratives of International Development had at that time. Fore rather than placing research from the Global South—and in turn the researchers generating the knowledge— in conversation (i.e. in collaboration) with research and researchers from the Global North, the session groupings reflected colonial narratives of isolating and exoticizing research from and of the Global South. Such colonial narratives are still maintained today, however, the internationalization of our community and the strengthening voices of researchers from the Global South within the collaborative effort of conference programming is beginning to disrupt such narratives. For example, several of the panellists have raised questions that were well received within 2020 CHI subcommittee PC meetings regarding the isolation of research from the Global South into sessions that are not thematically integrated into other relevant sessions within the CHI programme.

The above provided overview highlights the international nature of our community that has resulted in and is a result of North-South collaborations. Furthermore, as the voices of those of us from the Global South grow, so has the questioning and challenging of the ways through which we as a community understand, represent and engage in North-South collaborations. This panel aims to initiate a wider discussion on North-South collaborations within an ethos of learning and unlearning as we formulate ways forward for equitable, decolonial and just configurations of North-South collaborations.

3 PANEL FORMAT

3.1 Pre-panel Activities

Three weeks prior to the panel taking place, the panel organizers and panellists will use social media and mailing lists to advertise the panel. We will also share a Slido link through which members of our wider HCI communities can anonymously pose questions and share experiences with the panelists. The Slido forum will be open for two weeks, eliciting responses that will then be curated by the organizers and shared with panelists prior to the panel. Panelists will be encouraged to use these responses in shaping their contribution to the panel discussion. Furthermore, moderators will select responses shared via Slido to be posed for discussion during the panel session.

3.2 Panel Activities

The panel will be hybrid (held in-person with some panellists and attendees participating virtually) and will include 7 panellists engaging in research from and in varying geographies including Latin America, Africa, South Asia, the Middle East and North Africa region, Australia, North America and Europe. The number of panellists is warranted as they will each speak from the perspective of the geographies they are in and the geographies they are connected to. The panel will be moderated by two of the organizers, with

one moderator facilitating the in-person component and another moderating the virtual component.

A moderator will open the panel by introducing the topic to be discussed, the panellists as well as the panel's guide for ways of being and communicating together (10 minutes). The guide will draw on ACM's policy against discrimination and harassment as well as the code of conduct developed for the 2022 Participatory Design Conference in order to promote a respectful environment for all. Each panel member will then be invited to provide a 3-minute response to one of the following questions from their diverse perspectives (the coordination of which question each panelist will tackle will be agreed amongst the panelists prior to the panel):

- What are the joys that come from North-South HCI collaborations?
- What are the tensions that come with North-South collaborations?
- What are the significant improvements in thinking and learning/unlearning that have arisen from North-South collaborations?
- What languages of collaboration and terminologies should we be challenging and/or introduce into HCI?
- What are the lessons learnt so far in engaging North-South collaborations within our SIGCHI communities?
- How do we engage with meaningful explorations and mitigations of power dynamics in North-South collaborations in a manner that accounts for the colonial legacies that shape our ways of working?
- Have we progressed in challenging narratives in which scholars in the Global South are viewed as data collectors, fixers and facilitators of HCI research? And how do we move away from such narratives if they still persist?
- How do we ensure that space is given within collaborations to engage with epistemological pluralities across geographies?
- How has/can SIGCHI, and in turn CHI, move forward in creating a culture that places epistemic and ontological justice at the fore of building our North-South collaborative communities?
- What are the things we can do better when engaging in North-South collaborations within our CHI communities?
- Can North-South collaborations disconnect from International Development discourses and systems that have shaped how research from and in the Global South is conducted and represented?

These questions may be subject to change based on the responses elicited via Slido.

After each panellist has responded to a question (21 minutes) we will then open the floor for audience participation and discussion. Both the in-person and virtual audience members will be encouraged to share differing opinions on what has been discussed so far and to pose questions to the panel members and wider audience that would further the discussion. The discussion will first open for virtual attendees followed by opening the discussion to in-person attendees (35 minutes). Remote attendees would be able to share their opinions and questions through Zoom's chat function that the

virtual moderator will pose to the panel and the in-person moderator will facilitate the in-person audience contributions. The panel will close with each panellist providing one sentence (1 minute each) reflecting on their imaginaries for the future of North-South collaborations within HCI.

3.2.1 Logistical Needs and Hybrid Requirements. Due to the hybrid nature of the panel, we would require A/V support typical for a hybrid event including a camera set-up to stream the in-person panel members on Zoom as well as a projector to stream remote panel members and attendees into the physical room. 1-2 student volunteers to pass the microphone for questions and comments from in-person attendees and 2 student volunteers to help the virtual moderator facilitate the Zoom room.

4 PANELLISTS & PANEL ORGANIZERS

The panel will be moderated by the organizers:

Reem Talhouk is an Assistant Professor in the School of Design and Centre for International Development at Northumbria University. She is also the co-lead of the Design Feminisms Research Group that aims to explore the plurality of feminist research and design. Her research has explored ways through which participatory design and its outputs may generate decolonial counter-narratives within the humanitarian and global development technological space. She has led research, workshops and SIGs focused on Technology, Design and Migration.

Shaimaa Lazem is an Associate Research Professor at the City of Scientific Research and Technology Applications (SRTA-City), Egypt. She earned her Ph.D. in Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) from Virginia Tech, USA. Her research interests include participatory design, co-design, HCI and CS education, decolonising HCI, and cross-cultural collaborations. She has been a Leaders-in-Innovation Fellow with the Royal Academy of Engineering in London since 2018. In 2016, She co-founded ArabHCI, an initiative to promote HCI research and education in Arab countries. She is currently working on designing and deploying an innovative curriculum on Responsible Human-Centered AI for AI start-ups in Africa as part of a Google Research for Inclusion and Google AI awards with Professor Anicia Peters from the University of Namibia.

Ebtisam Al Abdulqader is a social innovation and digital health design researcher, and an experienced Assistant Professor in the Information Technology Department at King Saud University (KSU). She has a PhD in HCI on digital health interaction design from Newcastle University, UK, and she is the founder of the ArabHCI.org community. Ebtisam is interested in HCI aspects of social computing, interaction design, CSCW and community-driven research. She is an active professional member with a history of volunteer work with the ACM SIGCHI. She is also experienced in organizing CHI workshops and meetings on topics of CHI Inclusion, CHIveristy, and ArabHCI.

The panelists below were selected to provide diverse perspectives from the geographies they work in and from, varying career stages as well as from both industry and academia.

Marisol Wong-Villacrés is an Associate Professor at Escuela Superior Politécnica del Litoral in Ecuador. She explores how cultural

and learning science theories can inform an assets-based participatory design of technologies that support historically marginalized groups, such as immigrant families from developing regions, in pursuing sustainable, emancipatory transformations. She has experience facilitating co-design processes in the United States and Ecuador where various stakeholders—including computer science students, institutional staff, and members of vulnerable communities—work together to unpack and leverage existing strengths rather than trying to fix deficits or lacks. Marisol is also member of the ACM SIGCHI Latin American Committee, where she works on initiatives that highlight the lessons that HCI and CSCW research can draw from Latin America.

Kagonya Awori is a senior Applied Scientist at Microsoft - the Microsoft Africa Research Institute in Kenya - leading research and strategy for the Future of Work in Africa. She has over 10 years' experience leading technology research and design work/teams across the globe in Kenya, United Kingdom, and Australia. Throughout her work, Kagonya is centered on creating knowledge on, for and with people and businesses in Africa, and building intelligent solutions for Africa that can be scaled globally. Outside work, she greatly enjoys traveling, open water swimming, archery, and mentoring the youth - especially women.

Zainab AlMeraj is a faculty member at the Information Science Department at Kuwait University with backgrounds in computer graphics and HCI, and a certified usability and digital accessibility professional. Zainab's investigations often target the crossroads of social entrepreneurship, tech empowerment at grass roots level and human rights. She is passionate about building an innovative, universally designed, digitally inclusive future for everyone.

Tariq Zaman is an Associate Professor in the School of Computing and Creative Media at the University of Technology Sarawak (UTS) Malaysia. His projects and research publications equally reflect the multiple voices of indigenous wisdom and cultural understanding by converging local, scientific, traditional and cultural knowledge(s).

Neha Kumar is an Associate Professor at Georgia Tech in the Sam Nunn School of International Affairs and the School of Interactive Computing and leads the Technology and Design for Empowerment Lab. Neha's research is at the intersection of human-centered computing and global development and engages in participatory and assets-based approaches to design for/with historically underserved communities. Neha is the current SIGCHI president, has been leading in organizing and supporting the HCI Across Borders event series at CHI that aims to promote collaboration across borders in HCI and is the former Chair of ACM's Future of Computing Academy.

Volker Wulf is a Professor in the field of Socio-Informatics at the University of Siegen. Starting with investigating the Arab Spring, he and his team have worked in different counties of the Global South (Tunisia, Palestine, Syria, Madagascar, Botswana, Colombia, Ghana, Morocco, and Iran). He is most interested in understanding life practices in a wide range of domains – with a perspective on initiating social change.

Cat Kutay is an Aboriginal and Celtic Australian working in Northern Australia and previously in urban and rural communities to develop software for supporting language learning and story sharing. Working at the cultural interface creates many conflicts

over values and opportunities that introduce cultural change. Cat is a researcher and lecturer providing Aboriginal viewpoints and knowledge to expand students' understanding.

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